

OLD WABASH HOTEL
EDWARDSVILLE ILLINOIS
MADISON Co.

HABS-NO. ILL.-236

HABS

ILL,

60. EDVI,

1 -

Reduced Copies of Measured Drawings

PHOTOGRAPHS
WRITTEN HISTORICAL AND DESCRIPTIVE DATA
DISTRICT NO. ILL.-2

HISTORIC AMERICAN BUILDINGS SURVEY
EDGAR E. LUNDEEN - DISTRICT OFFICER
CORN BELT BANK BUILDING - BLOOMINGTON ILL.

OLD WABASH HOTEL
Edwardsville, Madison County, Illinois

Owner. Mr. Joseph Vella.

Date of Erection. About 1839.

Architect. Unknown.

Builder. Unknown.

Present Condition. The present brick structure is in good condition. The two story porch which originally extended across the front, and the two story frame portion on the rear, has been removed.

Number of Stories. Three.

Materials of Construction. Foundations and exterior walls are solid brick masonry construction. Interior framing is oak with plaster partitions on wood studs, except in attic where the partitions are vertical wood boards and battens. No definite information has been located relative to the size and form of the two story frame portion that was attached to the rear of the building.

Other Existing Records. None.

Additional Data. The second hotel in Edwardsville was built by John T. Lusk, on the spot now occupied by the Wabash hotel. It was a large frame building, and was destroyed by fire in 1839. Meriam Paterson kept this hotel for a time. His successor was Horatio G. Street, and he was followed by Cassius Heskett. While Street was proprietor, about the year 1830, it was renowned for the excellence of

its fare and the superior manner in which it was conducted. The fashionable people of St. Louis patronized it during the summer months, and on Sundays it was a frequent resort of the citizens of Alton, who drove over for the purpose of obtaining a good meal and having, at the same time, a day's recreation.

It was during Heskett's administration that the old frame building burned down. The present brick structure was at once erected in its place and was considered, in that day, a remarkably fine specimen of architecture. "A two-storey porch extended across the front, the upper porch supported by heavy oak posts and with a railing. There was a belfry centering the roof. There was a frame addition at the rear, the second storey of which was used as an entertainment hall. In addition to the Main Street entrances there was a side entrance on Union Street, this entrance leading to the entertainment hall.

From 1839 to 1846 the place was known, and famously so, as "Heskett's Tavern." From 1846 until 1856, it was designated as the "Edwardsville Hotel." From 1856 until the Wabash Railroad came through in 1871, when the name of the hotel was changed to honor the new railroad, it was known as the "Marshall House," a man by name of Marshall being proprietor of it. It was generally spoken of as the "Marshall House" when Lincoln stayed there.

Before the Civil War the hotel was socially and politically important, men of legal and political fame making it

their headquarters, or at least dining there en route through Edwardsville on the stage. Political gatherings were frequently held here. The old hotel was a stage stop and its bell was rung to announce the arrival of the stage coach.

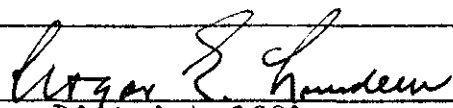
The entertainment hall, no longer a part of the building, was widely known for its social and political gatherings. The balls held there, particularly in the Heskett's Tavern days, were so magnificent for that era that the social elite came from as far away as the state capital and from St. Louis to attend them.

The political gathering that apparently obliterated the memory of all others was a dinner honoring Lincoln when he spoke in Edwardsville in the fall of 1858. An old Negress, who as an eleven-year old girl had got up at midnight to peel potatoes, told me about this dinner, two tables running the length of the flag-and bunting-trimmed room having to be set three times to accommodate the diners. And an old uncle of mine used to tell me about the parade to the Courthouse where Lincoln spoke following the dinner, he being one of the small boys of Democratic origin who tagged the procession shouting "Nigger lover!"

References: History of Madison County, 1862-1882.
W. R. Bunk & Co., Edwardsville, Illinois.
Page 340.

Letter of Miss R. Louise Travous,
Edwardsville, Illinois.

(Approved)


District Officer

Dec. 2nd. 3'36. THW